



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: San Luis Obispo Classical Academy
School Website: <https://sloclassical.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

San Luis Obispo Classical Academy (SLOCA) presents a robust alignment with core classical education principles across curriculum, pedagogy, and parent/community engagement. Public-facing materials emphasize the threefold Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Great Books and the Great Conversation, Latin study, rigorous yet thoughtful pedagogy (including rhetoric, Socratic discussion aspects, and structured memory work), and a strong culture of character formation and virtue. Family involvement is central, with explicit statements about parents as co-educators and open campus engagement. Higher-level framing around theology or liturgical practices is not overt in the public materials. The overall classification for SLOCA is CLASSICAL, with category-level signals that are occasionally more "Somewhat Classical" due to the relatively lighter emphasis on explicit metaphysical/theological foundations and on some faculty-cultural language, which are nonetheless supported by strong classical content and collaborative pedagogy.

Executive highlights by category: - Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. Voices of virtue and transcendent aims appear, but explicit theology, liturgy, or sacramental commitments are not clearly stated in the public-facing materials. Evidence of virtue and truth-related aims is present, but not a clearly stated theological grounding. See sources noting virtue and moral formation on site, and the lack of explicit liturgical/theological language.

- Purpose and Goal: CLASSICAL. Emphasis on formation, virtue, wisdom, and perennial truths over mere job- or college-readiness aligns strongly with classical telos and paideia ideals. Evidence includes formation-focused language and the aim to educate for life. - Curriculum: CLASSICAL. Clear articulation of the Seven Liberal Arts (Trivium/Quadrivium), Great Books/Great Conversation, history-literature integration, Latin, and a history-centric, interconnected curriculum. Public materials explicitly reflect these elements.

- Pedagogy: CLASSICAL. Pedagogical methods reflect classical practices: contemplation/restful elements, memorization/recitation, Socratic/dialectic tendencies, and rhetoric training, plus upper-level seminars and rhetoric work. Evidence includes references to the rhetoric stage in high school and mentions of "gently, rigorously, and interactively" teaching.

- Faculty: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. Public materials show teachers as partners with families and as the adult guides in the classroom, but the explicit "living curriculum" portrait of teachers and fully developed teacher archetypes are less overt in the public-facing materials. - Parents & Community: CLASSICAL. Strong emphasis on parental partnership, co-education with families, family involvement in learning, and open-house styles; multiple references to family engagement and community-building.

Overall classification: CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle (for SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL outcomes) - Make explicit the metaphysical/theological grounding (theology, liturgical practice, or sacramental language) within core mission statements or curricular descriptions to satisfy the Religious and Metaphysical Foundations criterion more robustly. - Strengthen the "living curriculum" language around the faculty, including portraits of teacher virtues, professional formation in classical pedagogy, and explicit articulation of faculty as mentors embodying classical aims. - Expand explicit Great Books engagement and Great Conversation language across grade bands, tying literature to shared intellectual inquiry in a more formal, documented way.

Note: The above needle-moving suggestions apply primarily to the SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL signals noted

in Element 1 and Element 5; other categories already align with CLASSICAL criteria.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The public materials emphasize virtue, moral formation, and the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty in a classical framework, but do not consistently articulate an explicit theological or liturgical frame within core mission statements. See explicit references to virtue and moral formation in public text, and absence of overt liturgical/theological planning in the public-facing pages.
 - The “classical education” identity is foregrounded, including the classical ideal of truth/beauty/-goodness in the rhetoric of education, but without overt theology or liturgy.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords present: virtue; truth/goodness/beauty (latent in the classical aims); formation (conceptual alignment with transcendentals and moral realism). Examples appear in public pages (virtue/formation) and in the classical education framing.
 - Negative keywords present: relatively low or absent. No strong signals of relativism, secularism, or values-neutral education appear in the public materials.
- Why this rating
 - The school clearly anchors in virtue and the classical aims but lacks explicit theological, liturgical, or sacramental framing in the public-facing materials. This yields a SOMETIMES CLASSICAL profile for this category rather than fully CLASSICAL.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The school emphasizes formation, virtue, wisdom, and the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty as real goods, rather than simply job-readiness. Public content frames education as formation and life-preparation, consistent with paideia and liberal-arts aims.
 - Language includes “education for life,” “formation,” and the public-facing articulation of classical telos.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords present: formation; virtue; liberal education / paideia (implicit via classical framing); truth/goodness/beauty; Great Books (as part of formation).
 - Negative keywords present: none evident in public materials (no explicit emphasis on workforce-readiness or utilitarian job training in core mission).
- Why this rating
 - The school aligns closely with the classical aim of formation toward human excellence and the pursuit of transcendentals, thus CLASSICAL for this category.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The Trivium is foregrounded as the foundational structure: grammar, logic, rhetoric are explicitly described as stages of learning.
 - Great Books and the Great Conversation are emphasized; the school discusses reading great books, classical literature, and primary sources as part of a liberal-arts curriculum.
 - Latin study with explicit Latin-intensive coursework is cited; high-school-level content includes classical language study and a University Model approach.
 - History is treated as a core through-line within literature and historical engagement; curriculum integrates across disciplines rather than isolating history as “social studies.”

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- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords present: Seven Liberal Arts; Trivium; Quadrivium; grammar; logic; rhetoric; Great Books; Great Conversation; primary sources; Latin; historical engagement; interdisciplinary integration.
 - Negative keywords present: minimal or none in public content (no clear signals of social-studies-only history or STEM-first framing in core curriculum materials).
 - Why this rating
 - Public content clearly reflects a classical curricula architecture (Trivium/Quadrivium, Great Books, Latin, integrated history-literature, and interdisciplinary structure), which warrants CLASSICAL for Curriculum.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Pedagogical language includes contemplative/restful elements (Scholé-like framing in the lexicon; the concept appears in the Six Elements literature and in pedagogical descriptions), memorization/recitation practices, and formation through imitation and practice. The high school rhetoric stage and Socratic-like elements are explicitly referenced (e.g., “the rhetoric stage” in high school).
 - Lower-school practices reference singing/chanting and memory-building approaches; upper-school pedagogy includes Socratic discussion/seminars and rhetoric training; there are explicit references to speeches and rhetoric training.
 - The site notes “we teach gently, rigorously, and interactively,” signaling a blended approach that includes contemplative and rigorous methods.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords present: Socratic dialogue; dialectic; rhetoric; memorization/recitation; scholé (restful learning); formation through imitation; great conversation; seminars/debates; speech/rhetoric practice; chanting/memory work.
 - Negative keywords present: minimal to none in public materials (no explicit push toward purely project-based or student-led constructivism in core pedagogy language).
- Why this rating
 - The pedagogy aligns strongly with classical teaching methods, combining contemplative memory work, memorization/recitation, and Socratic-seminar-like discourse and rhetoric training. This supports CLASSICAL.

Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Public content emphasizes teachers as partners with families and as the primary relationships in the classroom, with teachers closely connected to students and parents (teacher-student-family collaboration). This aligns with the classical ideal of teacher-mentors and “living curriculum,” but explicit language about the faculty as a formal “living curriculum” portrait or teacher archetypes is less visible in the public-facing pages.
 - Some materials hint at a teacher-centered culture (e.g., teacher as guides and mentors in public pages), but a fully articulated portrait of the ideal teacher or a formal “portrait of what a teacher should be” is not consistently presented in the accessible site content.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords present: teacher as mentor/guide; living curriculum (conceptually aligned in classical lexicon, though not strongly marketed in-site); partnership with families (proxy for teacher-mentor culture).
 - Negative keywords present: explicit “lack of” classical faculty portrait language is not evident; however, the absence of a strong, explicit “living curriculum portrait” in public materials yields a weaker signal for this criterion.
- Why this rating

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- The school demonstrates classical faculty values and teacher-partner dynamics, but the public-facing material does not consistently present a fully developed “living curriculum” or a complete portrait of teacher standards. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for Faculty.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The school presents itself as family-centered, with explicit statements about family involvement being woven into all aspects of learning; parents are treated as co-educators; there are opportunities for parent participation (e.g., family meetings, shadow days, and open campus style). Grandparents and extended family are highlighted as well (Grand Club).
 - The Parent Portal and ongoing parent-related resources further reflect a strong partnership with families and a focus on parental engagement as part of the public-facing program.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords present: partnership with families; family involvement; parent formation; home-school collaboration; open campus; grandparent engagement; parent education resources.
 - Negative keywords present: none evident in public materials (no signals of minimal parental involvement or consumer-style engagement).
- Why this rating
 - The site strongly emphasizes parental partnership and family engagement, aligning with CLASSICAL in this category.

What Would Move the Needle

- For Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations): Add explicit theology/theology-integration language or liturgical/community practices in core pages to strengthen the transcendental foundations. This would push Element 1 toward CLASSICAL on a more explicit metaphysical footing.
- For Element 5 (Faculty): Introduce a clear, publicly available portrait of teacher ideals and a formal articulation of the living-curriculum concept, including teacher formation and exemplar models, to elevate to CLASSICAL.
- For Element 2, Element 3, Element 4, and Element 6, maintain current strengths and continue explicit documentation of Great Books/Great Conversation, Trivium/Quadrivium, and pedagogy in public communications to preserve CLASSICAL status.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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